Four People Just Finished a Year of Pretend Mars Life

From: ScienceDaily All Mined: 2026-11-11 3 min read

Four NASA **volunteers** have finally stepped outside after more than a year of living as if they were on Mars. The crew finished their pretend Mars trip on October 31, 2026. They never left Earth, but they lived like future Mars explorers. The four **volunteers** are Matthew Montgomery, James Spicer, Ross Elder, and Ellen Ellis. They were part of NASA's **CHAPEA** program, which studies how people handle long space trips. During the year, they did jobs that Mars explorers may need to do. They tested systems, grew **crops**, saved **supplies**, and did **spacewalks** work outside their home. They also had to deal with slow messages from Earth. On Mars, radio signals take a long time to travel, so astronauts cannot get quick help from **mission control**. They must solve problems on their own. Keeping a crew healthy far from Earth is one of the hardest parts of going to Mars. NASA uses pretend missions like this to learn before real trips. What the crew learned will help NASA plan its Moon Base and future trips to Mars.

Word Treasure

volunteers -- Volunteers are people who do a job for free, without being paid.
CHAPEA -- CHAPEA is NASA's program that studies how people handle long space trips.
spacewalks -- A spacewalk is work done outside a spacecraft or home in space.
mission control -- Mission control is the team on Earth that helps astronauts.
crops -- Crops are plants grown for food.
supplies -- Supplies are things you need, like food and tools.

Background you need

NASA is the American space agency, and it plans to send astronauts to Mars one day.

Before a real trip, NASA runs pretend missions on Earth to see how people handle living far from home.

On Mars, radio signals take a long time to travel, so astronauts must solve problems on their own without quick help from Earth.

Break it down

WHO: Four NASA volunteers: Matthew Montgomery, James Spicer, Ross Elder, and Ellen Ellis.
WHAT: The crew finished a year-long pretend Mars trip, living as if they were on Mars without ever leaving Earth.
WHERE: On Earth, inside a pretend Mars home built by NASA.
WHY: Because NASA wants to learn how people handle long space trips before sending real astronauts to Mars.

Why it matters

One day astronauts may live on Mars, and pretend missions like this one teach us how people can stay healthy and work together far from home.

Test what you remember

1. How long did the pretend Mars trip last?

- (A) More than a year
- (B) Ten years
- (C) One week
- (D) One month

2. When did the crew finish their pretend Mars trip?

- (A) October 31, 2025
- (B) December 1, 2026
- (C) October 31, 2026
- (D) September 1, 2026

3. What is NASA's CHAPEA program?

- (A) A program that grows food on the Moon
- (B) A program that builds rockets
- (C) A program that trains pilots
- (D) A program that studies how people handle long space trips

4. What jobs did the crew do during the year?

- (A) They tested systems, grew crops, saved supplies, and did spacewalks
- (B) They flew to the Moon and back
- (C) They built a new rocket
- (D) They trained animals for space

5. Why can't astronauts on Mars get quick help from Earth?

- (A) The crew refused to call for help
- (B) Earth is too far to see
- (C) There are no radios on Mars
- (D) Radio signals take a long time to travel

6. What will what the crew learned help NASA plan?

- (A) Its Moon Base and future trips to Mars
- (B) A mission to the bottom of the ocean
- (C) Trips to the Sun
- (D) A new space station on Earth

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: C 3: D 4: A 5: D 6: A

Questions to think about

1. NASA: Uses pretend missions to learn before real trips to Mars.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):